

ANNA NAGAR

Purasawalkam » Villivakkam » Kolathur » Nazarathpettai » Pattabiram » Maduravoyal » Koyambedu » Tiruverkadu » Puzhal » Kilpauk » Perambur » Mogappair
Avadi » Ayyapakkam » Tiruninravur » Nerkundram » Moolakadai » Ayanavaram » Retteri » Padi » Ambattur » Tirumullaivoyal » Aminjikarai » Vysarpadi » Red Hills



GEN ZERS 'REEL' IN VISIBILITY FOR MODEST CLOTHING STORE

Organic social media content posted on Instagram by customers impressed with its range of trendy tops for women is ensuring an enviable customer base for Rani Collection in Pondy Bazaar, one extending beyond the Indian shores **P5**



A SINGING CIRCLE SPANNING THE CITY

Fuelled by Tamil music nostalgia, a community of amateur singers meet regularly across Chennai for singalongs. **P6**

ICF Loco Works bridge 'derails' into dangerous disrepair

The central part of the bridge is battered

G. KUMAR

The one-kilometre-long ICF Loco Works bridge in ICF Loco Works with one "foot" in Ayanavaram and another in Villivakkam has a problem around its central part.

Accounting for a distance of 50 metres, this section of a hugely useful and busy bridge is pockmarked with potholes. The bitumen has considerably worn off, and one small patch has a metal sheet.

Motorists of all stripes are affected by this state of affairs, the level of inconvenience dictated by the number of wheels, movement getting uncomfortably bumpy for motorcyclists. For motorcyclists, the pitted surface can prove costly, as during hour, when motorists tend to speed, there could be dangerous skids.

When local Greater Corporation officials were contacted seeking redemptive action on this section of the bridge, they informed that the bridge comes under the maintenance of Southern Railway.

The broken-down section of this bridge is a compelling illustrating of civic apathy as it has continued to be in this state for at least five years now. As this section of the bridge would naturally get battered more as vehicles would linger here longer than on the ascent and descent, it should receive extra attention.

Motorists want the railways to take action, mend that part of the bridge and improve the user experience for motorists frequenting it.

(G. Kumar is a resident of Villivakkam)

▼
The battered section.



'Road in Kilpauk is poorly lit'

For the past seven months, a good number of street lamp poles are without a lamp on Medavakkam Tank Road in Kilpauk. This is quite unsafe. I request the Greater Chennai Corporation to attend to this issue at the earliest.

D.Radhakrishnan
is a resident of Kilpauk



You can be our volunteer writer



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Road safety campaign by Shenoy Nagar residents *turns one*



This August, the road safety campaign organised by the East Shenoy Nagar Residents Association will be completing a year. During this period, the Association has conducted 33 campaigns.

The campaigns were conducted largely on key roads of Shenoy Nagar including Pulla Avenue, Third Cross Street, Lakshmi Talkies Road and West Park Road.

"These roads witness heavy traffic during peak hours. The awareness drives are generally held on Wednesdays. Children take part in the Sunday drives held near Thiru Vi Ka park. Residents campaign by holding placards encouraging mo-

torists to slow down, wear helmets and seat belts, and drive on the left side of the road. This has received encouraging response from many motorists, who often give a thumbs up or a nod to the timely reminder to follow traffic rules," says V.M. Chinni Krishnan, a member of the Association and a marathon runner.

He along with Thyagarajan, another marathon runner, used to carry placards on road safety during their morning runs.

"We generally run for 10 km in the roads of Shenoy Nagar, Anna Nagar, and sometimes in Adyar. During this fitness exercise, we try to spread this message of following

road safety rules," adds Chinni Krishnan.

With road accidents continuing to rise in the city and across the country, the residents of Shenoy Nagar are doing their part in spreading the message of road safety.

"The footpaths in Shenoy Nagar, especially the ones along Thiru Vi Ka park are usurped by parking of vehicles. The road around the park witnesses heavy traffic during weekends and pedestrians have no option other than walking on the thoroughfares. According to India Road Accidents Data - 2024, a report published by the Ministry of Road Transport &



The campaign; and (below) a footpath at Shenoy Nagar.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Highways, Government of India, released recently, Chennai recorded 542 accident deaths and of which pedestrians accounted for 186. It may be noted that the Supreme Court of India, in a judgement in June 2026, declared the freedom to walk on demarcated and well-maintained footpaths a fundamental right and this shall override the privilege of a motor-

ised vehicle. The report also says: Tamil Nadu reported the highest number of road accidents on National Highways for the seventh consecutive year, reporting 20,672 accidents (13.7%) on National Highways. Hence, it is important that people comply with these safety rules diligently and authorities on their part should enforce the rules," adds Chinni Krishnan.

New park getting ready in Ambattur

Greater Chennai Corporation is setting up a new park in Govindan Street at Oragadam near Ambattur. According to a Greater Chennai Corporation official, the area of the park is close to 1,000 sqft.

"The recreational space is largely meant for children. A good part of the work is over. It is being developed at a cost of ₹21 lakh, a capital fund of GCC," says the official.

The park falls under Ward 79 of Zone 7 - Ambattur of GCC.



The park in Govindan Street at Oragadam.

Grand felicitation for a **Grandmaster**



Dwaraka Doss Goverdhan Doss Vaishnav College (Autonomous) in Arumbakkam organised a grand felicitation ceremony on July 27, 2026 to honour

Grandmaster R. Pragganandhaa, a second-year B.B.A. student, for his outstanding achievements in international chess.

The occasion also celebrated the college's historic feat of win-

ning the prestigious University of Madras Dr. Sivanthi Adityan Rolling Trophy for the third consecutive year (2023-24, 2024-25 and 2025-26). Nearly 3,000 students gathered to welcome and cele-

brate this remarkable achievement, says a press release.

PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

In his keynote address, principal Capt. S. Santhosh Baboo, congratulated Grandmaster R. Pragganandhaa and the champion teams on their historic achievements, stating that while winning a trophy is a proud moment, retaining it is the true challenge.

Chief guest V. K. Ramkumar, Member of the Legislative Assembly, Anna Nagar Assembly Constituency, congratulated Grandmaster R. Pragganandhaa for bringing pride to the college and the nation.

The ceremony featured the formal felicitation of Grandmaster R. Pragganandhaa, who was presented with a cash prize of ₹1,00,000 in recognition of his outstanding achievements in international chess. Cash prizes totalling ₹4,00,000 were awarded to the 138 students and 10 coaches who played a pivotal role in securing the Dr. Sivanthi Adityan Rolling Trophy for the third consecutive year.

In his acceptance speech, Pragganandhaa urged students to dream big, keep their ambitions high and aim for the sky with dedication, discipline and confidence while pursuing their goals.

Toastmasters club to meet today in Anna Nagar

Anna Nagar Orators Toastmasters Club is organising its meet August 2 at Kailash Yoga Kendra, Y Block, Anna Nagar. Time: At 10 a.m. According to a press release, the programme is open to all. It will be of interest to those who want to improve their communication and leadership skills. No fee will be charged, adds the press release. For details, call 99400 84055.

Talent hunt contest for persons with disabilities

DSW Trust along with Rotary Club of Centennial Madras is inviting persons with special needs for the second edition of its talent hunt competition.

During the launch of the event held recently, the Trust urged the Government to fast-track UDID card issuance; provide priority allotment of Tamil Nadu Housing Board homes for persons with disabilities; increase employment opportunities in Government departments; and simplify the process for opening joint bank accounts for adults with disabilities and their parents/legal guardians.

For details, call 9043407150.

Registration: <https://forms.gle/QakRdE7JfY8n57rq9>

20th Graduation Day at college in Avadi



The ceremony was celebrated with great pride and enthusiasm, bringing together graduates, parents, faculty members and distinguished guests, says a press release.

A total of 370 students were awarded their degrees in recognition of their successful completion of their academic programmes.

The event commenced with the welcome address delivered by E. Mary Angeline Santhosham, principal and sustainable educator. The chief guest, Prof. Rita John, Registrar of the University of Madras, delivered an inspiring graduation address, encouraging the graduates to pursue excellence, uphold integrity, and contribute meaningfully to society, the release adds.

The ceremony was graced by the presence of E. Mary Angeline Santhosham, principal, E. Mano Ranjitham, vice principal and innovation ambassador, and other members of the college management and faculty.

Three-day cultural event



A three-day cultural event called was held at Chevalier T. Thomas Elizabeth College for Women. According to a press release, around 1,500 school and college students took part. Called Tiranika, Kalakiran and Chainika 2026, the event was marked

by music, dance, theatre, literature, and fine arts.

One of the highlight was *Mudiyum Mudiyaadhu*, a theatre production that explored mental health concerns including depression, anxiety, obsessive-compulsive disorder and schizophrenia.

The skits were about social issues such as alcoholism, corruption, protection of the girl child.

Traditional games such as *Pallangoli*, *Kazhangu*, *Ammanai*, *Paandi* and *Sadugudu*, were conducted. A blood donation drive was also conducted.

Gen Zers 'reel'

in visibility for modest clothing store

Organic social media content posted on Instagram by customers impressed with its range of trendy tops for women is ensuring an enviable customer base for Rani Collection in Pondy Bazaar, one extending beyond the Indian shores



Sikkander Sultan now; and an old photo of his shop in Pondy Bazaar that functions without a nameboard.

buyers' Instagram accounts.

Rani Collection run by Sikkander Sultan is nourished by healthy organic social media content, posted by customers on their Instagram pages impressed with its range of trendy tops for women and girls. Rani Collection operates from a small space within another store and for the convenience of its customers, a small part of it often spills on to a space under a tree without being underfoot. The sanctity of the pedestrian space is maintained.

Street Feed

A column about the quotidian on the streets of Chennai that finds itself in the spotlight on social media because residents took to it, and in cases involving a modest enterprise, customers were so impressed with its products that they drummed up a buzz around it through reels and posts

"Nearly 85 percent of our customers come through reels. Influencers visit us regularly, and that is how most of the people get to know about our shop," he says.

Gen Zers largely home in on this shop, and Sikkander himself is no spring chicken, being at least one generation removed. His family soaked in the garment business, Sikkander slid into the trade as effortlessly as one would through an open door, without any existential cogitations about purpose and calling. He established the shop at Pondy Bazaar in 2013, a good six years before pedestrianisation transformed the street into a congregating point, particularly for Gen Z. Sneakers-wearing Gen Zers now flit-

ting in, in good numbers, Rani Collection could not have kept Insta visibility off its racks even if it tried to. It draws shoppers from far beyond Chennai, much of that, says Sikkander, is thanks to Instagram. The reach however is not confined to the state. After spotting the store on Instagram, a customer travelling from Kolkata stopped by during their visit to Chennai. Others have walked in from Malaysia and Sri Lanka after watching viral reels, while some families in the United Kingdom and the United States often shop through relatives visiting Chennai. Depending on the size of the order, the store also ships internationally. Rani Collection offers trendy tops starting at ₹300, while complete sets are priced between ₹500 and ₹3000. Even a purchase as small as ₹300 can be exchanged, and the customer can be certain he would not be met with an irritated frown. As Sikkander puts it, "We want our customers to confidently wear what they buy."

If a garment is pushed to the back of a closet, it does injustice to the tailor who carefully stitched it. Every single thread reflects their hard work. I have seen their daily struggles, and I want their work to be valued." Beyond the bustling shop floor is a business man whose outlook is as contemporary as the collection he curates. He believes businesses must evolve with changing times, embracing new ideas and remaining relevant to a young demographic. Sikkander notes honesty and hard work are non-negotiables: open from 10:30 a.m to 10:30 p.m, seven days a week, "break" and "rest" sound like gibberish in Sikkander's ears. Without normalising workaholicism, one has to acknowledge this commitment just as one would this pavement store's rack strength and its owner's affordability. And Gen Zers are doing that with likes, reposts and reels on Instagram.

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

As the Pedestrian Plaza in Pondy Bazaar wears a twilight glow, young shoppers shuffle towards a modest clothing store near 'Crocs' store opposite Geetha Cafe. One shopper browses the displays, eyes peeled for that perfect dress,

and comes upon it, unfortunately, seconds too late. She eats her heart out watching it disappear into someone else's ravenous shopping bag. Friends hold up outfits for each other, debate colours and designs, and leave with a heavier bag, a lighter purse and a sprightlier step. Qualms written all over her face,

another shopper admits: "Here to keep a friend company while she shopped, I ended up with a shopping bag of my own. The seller's warmth won me over." On-the-spot reviews of this timbre do not dissipate but solidify into eWOM (electronic word of mouth), gaining permanence as reels and stories on

A singing circle spanning the city

Fuelled by Tamil music nostalgia, a community of amateur singers meet regularly across Chennai for singalongs. They are bound together by an organisation called Paadarivom Padipparivom which funnels its initiatives through an app

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Paadarivom Padipparivom traces its origins to the lockdowns of 2020. Former IT professional Naggeshwerran S., aged 43, known as NGR in the music community, noticed a pattern while scrolling through the Smule karaoke app.

"People were singing because they enjoyed it, but many of them were also being mocked online. We realised there were many people who wanted to sing but did not know where to learn," says Naggeshwerran.

A decision to do something about this led to free live sessions on Facebook and YouTube, where participants got to learn one Tamil song every week. The lessons were as simple as they can be: songs were broken down into simple sounds and rhythmic patterns. "I have been singing since 1992, but I never learnt Carnatic music. Friends would teach me using sounds instead of swaras. We thought if this method worked for me, it could work for others too," he says. The first session, held on May 4, 2020, drew close to 500 viewers, far exceeding the organisers' expectations. Requests for regular classes soon followed, leading to the formation of Paadarivom Padipparivom.

The community now operates from two studios –Madipakkam and Saligramam which serve as its primary spaces for learning and singing. Each studio can accommodate around 25-30 people and hosts regular singing classes, rehearsals, karaoke sessions and community singalongs. Members also gather there for Jam Along Vaanga, where they perform solo or duet songs before an audience.

As participation grew, the community began extending beyond its studios. An invitation from Cookgram restaurant in Anna Nagar led to regular singalong sessions at the venue on the first and third Friday of every month. The sessions, which combine music with a shared meal, accommodate around 65 to 70 participants and are consistently full. The group has since partnered with an event ve-



From singalong sessions organised by Paadarivom Padipparivom.

nue in Adyar for larger singalong sessions and has also received requests from a venue on OMR to host similar events. A majority of those who join are above the age of 30. "Most activities in music are designed for children or youngsters. We wanted to create something for people in their thirties, forties, fifties and beyond. Many of them are not looking for a career in music. They simply want a place where they can sing without being judged," says Naggeshwerran.

The organisation follows a structured cinema music curriculum rather than teaching only individual songs. Learners are introduced to concepts such as pitch, rhythm and expression through familiar film songs. Since 2020, the team has released lessons for nearly 300 Tamil film songs, each available on YouTube for learners to revisit.

As interest grew, the organisers realised members wanted opportunities to sing outside the classroom. This led to the launch of Jam Along Vaanga, a karaoke programme where participants perform solo or duet songs before an audience. "We call it 'Bathroom to

Green Room'. Many people only sing inside their homes. We wanted to create a path where they could first learn, then practise and finally perform before an audience," says Naggeshwerran.

The community now has around 3,000 members across WhatsApp groups, with participants from 26 countries joining both physical and online events.

An auction of singers

The group also organises Paattu Paarak, a singing competition inspired by the Indian Premier League. Participants are grouped into teams of six through a conceptual auction, without any exchange of money. Teams then compete in a cricket-style format, chasing each other's total scores across multiple rounds. The finals are organised as fundraising events, with the proceeds donated to charitable organisations. In the past two years, funds raised through the competition have been contributed to Akshaya Homes, a free residential home for destitute senior citizens.

Registrations for all events are managed through the group's PP Music mobile app. Participants can register, make payments and reserve slots for singalongs, competitions and other programmes through the app. Paadarivom Padipparivom has kept the registration fee for a singalong event at ₹299 to make it accessible to more people. Members with an annual subscription can attend events without paying separately, as the fee is included in their membership.

Beyond registrations, the app functions as a learning platform. Users can access free teaching videos, submit recordings of songs for feedback from mentors, and receive personalised comments on areas for improvement. It also features a "Voice Bank", where aspiring singers can store their recordings, a digital library of solo and duet lessons in Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam and Hindi for annual members, competition registrations, and a chat section that allows members to interact with one another.

For further details, contact 86680 18282 or @ppmusic0405 on Instagram



A singalong on wheels today

The Bus Singalong is Paadarivom Padipparivom's latest initiative. The Bus Singalong on August 2 with two routes across Chennai was initially planned with one bus for around 50 participants. When registrations opened through the group's mobile app, around 40 people signed up within one and a half hours. The response led to the addition of a second bus, taking the total registrations to around 85-90.

The bus sing-along event will take place from 3:00 p.m. to 8:00 p.m. Registrations have now closed, as the organisers have already received 90 registrations and booked two buses, which have reached full capacity.

Looking ahead, the organisers are exploring the possibility of hosting their next sing-along event aboard the Cordelia Cruise. While discussions are still in the preliminary stages, those interested can stay updated by following the group's Instagram page for future announcements and registration details.



The dignitaries on stage and a section of the audience.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



LIFY THOMAS

Humour Club International - Triplicane chapter made its 43rd anniversary special carrying forward a practice they started in 2016. For the 10th continuous year, the Club honoured four war widows, acknowledging their personal loss and supporting them with a financial assistance of ₹ one lakh each. In 2016, during an official visit to Srinagar, R. Sekharan, secretary of the Club, met some families who had lost their children protecting the borders. Their stories left a deep scar on him. Later, with the approval of the committee members of the Triplicane chapter they started to support families of war heroes financially. Instead of just crediting the amount to their accounts, the

10 years of service to kin of war heroes

Four war widows were honoured with financial assistance at the 43rd anniversary celebration of Humour Club International - Triplicane chapter

Club goes all out to reflect and honour the sacrifice war widows endure with a fitting tribute that was held this time at Kamaraj Arangam in Teynampet.

From one war widow in 2016, this time they had four of them who were honoured. In the last 10 years, close to 30 beneficiaries were identified.

Munvar Sultan, a retired banker and a member of the Club for over two decades, says they seek the help of Anandham Youth Foundation and the Pensioners Association who forwards some of the most deserving applications for them to scrutinise.

"Every year, we select two war widows and a good amount of the

financial assistance that we offer comes from the collection that we make during our monthly meetings. This time, two of our donors came on their own to support with the entire amount so we had four beneficiary in total," says Sultan.

The families chosen are from Tamil Nadu and the Club sponsors their travel, stay and other expenses

as a gesture of the sacrifice the 'hero' has made.

Started in 1983 with less than 15 members, the Triplicane chapter remains the most lively among humour clubs in the city. Their anniversary celebrations go to packed houses and is held at St Bede's School auditorium and the monthly meetings draw more than 600 members. Besides humour, the members have made this monthly outing meaningful adding a host of other social initiatives. They help Corporation workers and transgenders. "We give free grocery worth ₹ 2000 to the poor families and so far we have supported 185 families," says Sekharan.

Milestone years of couples who are their members is another event they look forward to.

On August 9, the Club celebrates its 44th year at Mylapore Fine Arts Club at 4 p.m.

Workshop on organic farming



Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre is conducting a workshop on organic farming of vegetable

crops on August 6. According to a press release, the session will focus on chemical-free methods of pest management, soil nourishment, and preparation of bio-manure. Participants will also learn about certification of organic products.

Another session on making soaps will be held on August 7. The programme is about making soaps from extracts of leaves, flowers, fruits, and herbs.

Both the session will be held at the centre's premises at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Guindy. For details, call 044 - 29530048

One-year certificate course on entrepreneurship

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, Guindy along with EDII - Ahmedabad is introducing a one-year certificate course on "Entrepreneurship and Innovation." According to a press release, classes will start on August 3. Graduates from any discipline from 21 to 40 years of age can apply. To apply visit: <https://editn.in/Web-One-Year-Registration> For details visit, www.editn.in Phone: 8668101638 / 8668107552.

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What will Chennai look like in 2096?

At Yein Udaan's eighth annual day function, children from the dhobighat communities showcased this futuristic idea with a variety of performances

July 25 was a memorable day for more than 100 children from the dhobighat communities of Chennai. At Yein Udaan's eighth annual day function, children presented 'Vanakkam Chennai 2096: A time travel story of hope' before an audience of 300 people at Shree Geetha Bhavan Trust in Gopalapuram.

The production provided a meaningful platform for children from an underserved urban community to showcase their talent, build confidence, and experience the joy of performing on a big stage.

Nawabzada Mohammed Asif Ali, Dewan and heir-apparent to the Prince of Arcot; Begum Seema Ahmed, a peace activist and a member of the Arcot Royal Family; and Re-



vathi Sai Prakash, Director of Sairam Institutions, were the chief guests.

Seeing their children dressed in colourful costumes, performing with all their heart, and receiving applause from a large audience was a moment of pride for the

parents, said a release.

The excitement of rehearsals, interactions with the producers, wearing their costumes, seeing the stage transformed by the LED display, and finally performing and hearing the audience applaud made them feel like ac-

tors for one evening. In addition, they were dancers and storytellers, too.

The story explored the choices we make today and the world we leave behind, touching upon the importance of protecting our water, trees, soil, food and environment, while using technology responsibly and preserving human connection, the release said.

The celebration continued beyond the stage, with children enjoyed meals provided by Hot Breads.

Yein Udaan welcomes individuals, organisations and institutions interested in supporting children and communities through partnerships, volunteering and collaborative opportunities. Email: malavika@yeinudaan.org.

An evening with Janaki amma

A musical tribute on August 9 will feature songs sung by the legendary playback singer



Samagratha Foundation is organising a musical tribute, 'Kaatril Undhan Geetham', in honour of the late legendary playback singer S. Janaki.

The concert will be held on August 9 at Vani Mahal at 5.30

p.m. and will feature the singer's timeless songs.

The event was originally conceived as a fundraiser. However, following the legendary singer's passing, the organisers have decided to conduct it as a free-entry tribute concert, ensuring the evening remains a sincere celebration of Amma's extraordinary musical legacy, said a release.

The programme will feature Janaki Amma's most memorable songs, presented by the singers of Samagratha, along with singers from Zee Tamil SaRiGaMaPa, accompanied by a live orchestra.

For details, call Vinod Venugopal, founder, Samagratha Foundation, at 98410 71971. WhatsApp 63817 88551 to know your nearest collection point.



Medisocyl launches mobile applications

Medisocyl, a unit of Good Samaritan Health Care Services, has launched its mobile and web applications to drive the digital transformation of healthcare.

The event was held at VHS - M.A. Chidambaram College of Nursing, Taramani, and saw more than 250 healthcare professionals, nursing faculty and industry stakeholders.

Dr. Shankar Shanmugam, Registrar, Tamil Nadu Nurses and Midwifery Council, and Principal, Madras Medical College, was the chief guest.

Amalraj Ravi, founder and chairman of Medisocyl and Good Samaritan Health Care Services, said the applications have been developed with the vision of making quality healthcare more accessible, affordable, and

patient-centric.

Medisocyl is a digital platform that removes intermediaries, allowing patients to choose their preferred providers while enabling professionals to work independently and flexibly, according to a release.

The services offered include doctor home visits, nursing care, physiotherapy, baby care, elder care, and tele consultation.

A range of services are offered like scheduling to book verified nurses, doctors, and therapists from home; professional medical care at the doorstep; transparent pricing; secure digital records; and an escalation and refund mechanism.

For details, log on to <http://www.medisocyl.com>

Call: 89394 94229, 89394 94239, 89394 94249, and 89394 94259

Challani opens store in Sembakkam

Challani Jewelry Mart has opened a jewelry store 'Lille' on Velachery Main Road.

Tamil actress Dushara Vijayan inaugurated the store at Sembakkam in Selaiyur.

Lille is designed for women aged 16 to 34.

With a focus on minimalist and lightweight designs, the brand brings together elegance and affordability in every piece, from finely

crafted earrings and pendants to elegant necklaces and bangles.

Lille also offers men's bracelets, chains, and rings, and for children.

The brand also showcases an exquisite diamond collection featuring rings, earrings, pendants, necklaces, and bangles, enhanced with beautiful stones such as turquoise, amethyst, sapphire, ruby, and emerald.

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